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Public perceptions of responsible AI in local government: A multi-country study using the theory of planned behaviour

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ABSTRACT

The rise of Artificial Intelligence (AI) has significant implications for local government service delivery, offering considerable advantages alongside inherent risks that warrant careful management. While responsible AI has become a focal point in academic and policy discussions, public perceptions remain marginal in these debates. This paper explores how behavioural factors along with perceived risk, local government AI policy awareness and policy expectations influence public intentions to support local government responsible AI practices. Using the Theory of Planned Behaviour, this study examines a multi-factor survey through Confirmatory Factor Analysis, followed by Structural Equation Modelling to assess relationships between key factors. A survey questionnaire, conducted with participants from Australia, the United States, and Spain via the Prolific platform, reveals key insights: (a) perceived risk exhibit a stronger influence than other factors; (b) policy awareness plays a critical role in shaping public intention towards support for responsible practices; (c) greater AI policy awareness correlates with more realistic expectations of local government AI policies; (d) social influence lacks a notable impact in this context. These findings provide valuable guidance for urban policymakers in crafting AI strategies that promote responsible AI implementation within local government services.

1. Introduction

Local governments are progressively seeking to leverage artificial intelligence (AI) to enhance their operational capabilities (Yigitcanlar, David, et al., 2024; Yigitcanlar, Desouza, et al., 2025). A survey by the Public Technology Institute found that most local government officials in the US are concerned about the ethical and privacy risks of AI in public service delivery (Public Technology Institute, 2023). The 2023 Australian Local Government CEO Index reported that nearly 70 % of CEOs recognised AI's growing impact. Many expect significant transformations within the next five years (Australian Local Government, 2024).

AI in local government integrates a diverse array of technologies, systems and devices to revolutionise public service delivery and administrative functions (Bibri, Huang, & Krogstie, 2024; Kulal et al., 2024). This multifaceted domain encompasses machine learning (ML), deep learning (DL), and algorithms, empowering local authorities to conduct nuanced analyses of complex data sets and execute intricate tasks such as predictive modelling, forecasting, and resource optimisation (Wirtz et al., 2018; Yigitcanlar, Senadheera, et al., 2024). Moreover, advances in quantum computing and AI (Quantum AI) hold the potential to unlock new frontiers in local governance by enhancing computational efficiency and enabling more sophisticated decision-support systems (Yigitcanlar, Hossain, et al., 2025).

AI's distinguishing features in local governance, compared to traditional methods and non-AI technologies, include its adaptive capacity to

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address evolving community needs, its proficiency in managing multifaceted urban challenges, and its potential to automate and enhance decision-making processes (Bibri, Huang, Jagatheesaperumal, & Krogstie, 2024; Das, 2024). This rapid growth in AI adoption presents both advantages and hurdles for local governments worldwide (Alhosani & Alhashmi, 2024; Yigitcanlar, Agdas, & Degirmenci, 2023). As AI systems become more prevalent in local government operations, concerns about transparency, accountability, and ethical implications have grown (Desouza et al., 2015).

As the primary interface between citizens and public services, local governments hold a pivotal position in embracing and executing AI technologies (Rotta, Sell, Pacheco, & Yigitcanlar, 2019; Criado & Zarate-Alcarazo, 2022; Vogl et al., 2020). The central challenge for local governments is to responsibly integrate AI into public services in a way that fosters public trust and acceptance of the technology (Rakova et al., 2021; Robinson, 2020). Local government responsible AI practices refer to the ethical, transparent, and accountable use of AI technologies in municipal operations and services (David et al., 2024; Yigitcanlar, Senadheera, et al., 2024).

The intention behind these practices is to maximise AI's benefits, mitigate associated risks, and sustain public trust (Jakesch et al., 2022; Shneiderman, 2020). Understanding the factors that influence citizens' intentions to support local government responsible AI practices is therefore crucial (Gesk & Leyer, 2022). Failure to address public intentions may lead to resistance or distrust toward local governments, potentially undermining the advantages associated with AI adoption (Aoki, 2020; Leslie, 2019). Furthermore, public perception of what constitutes local government responsible AI practices may vary, reflecting diverse experience and concerns (Jakesch et al., 2022; Sartori & Bocca, 2022; Shneiderman, 2020).

The Theory of Planned Behaviour (TPB) is frequently employed to gain insights into individual intentions and behaviours. According to TPB, an individual's intention is influenced by attitude, perceived behavioural control, and subjective norms (Ajzen, 1991). Additional factors can be incorporated to enhance TPB's explanatory power (Hankins et al., 2000; Povey et al., 2000). In the context of AI, perceived risks—such as privacy and security concerns—can further shape intentions (Gupta et al., 2023; Solberg et al., 2022). Increased awareness of AI policies can also strengthen citizens' willingness to engage with responsible AI practices (Díaz-Rodríguez et al., 2023; Rakova et al., 2021). Meanwhile, intentions play a pivotal role in moulding public expectations (Ajzen, 2011), which in turn drive the demand for the transparency and ethical governance of AI (McCrea et al., 2024).

Despite growing interest in responsible AI practices, research has primarily focused on expert perspectives (Pant et al., 2023; Rakova et al., 2021; Yee & You, 2020), leaving public opinion limited. While some studies have examined public perceptions of responsible AI and individuals' intentions toward AI, findings reveal varying levels of support and opposition (Brauner et al., 2023; Gürkan & Suchow, 2024; Machado et al., 2025). However, there is still a lack of comprehensive research specifically examining public intentions to support responsible AI practices, particularly in local government. As behavioural intention serves as a significant predictor of actual behaviour (Conner & Norman, 2022; Sok et al., 2021), understanding these factors can help local governments develop AI solutions that align more closely with community needs and values (Riege & Lindsay, 2006; Virvou, 2023).

By actively involving citizen's perception, local governments can enhance accountability, improve decision-making processes, and foster transparency—key elements in building legitimacy and trust in AI-enabled public services (Dollbo, 2023; Kulal et al., 2024). Furthermore, a deeper understanding of public attitudes toward AI can help policymakers create more effective regulations that address citizens' specific concerns (Machado et al., 2025; Schiff et al., 2025). Prioritising public opinion in AI governance can ultimately lead to more trustworthy, widely accepted, and beneficial AI-driven services for local communities (Aoki, 2020; Machado et al., 2025).

This study explores the factors that shape public intentions to support responsible AI practices adopted by local governments. By integrating the TPB with factors such as perceived risk, policy awareness, and policy expectations, this study develops theoretical hypotheses to understand the drivers of public support for responsible AI practices. A comprehensive questionnaire was designed to empirically test these hypotheses, using structural equation modelling (SEM) to analyse the data and provide insights into the dynamics of public intention toward responsible AI practices at the local level. By leveraging established theoretical frameworks and robust statistical methods, we will provide a nuanced understanding of the complex dynamics involved in responsible AI governance at the local level.

This study's insights will drive advancements in theory and foster practical applications in the area, offering valuable guidance for local governments in crafting effective communication strategies, educational initiatives, engagement approaches, citizen-centric AI policies and regulatory frameworks. Ultimately, this research aims to lay the groundwork for more informed and citizen-focused strategies for implementing AI, fostering responsible and socially beneficial technological outcomes within local government settings.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows: Section 2 provides literature background and research hypotheses. Section 3 presents the methodological approach. Section 4 shares the analysis and results. Section 5 offers a discussion of the findings. Section 6 concludes the paper.

2. Literature background and research hypotheses

TPB has emerged as a valuable framework for predicting and analysing individual behaviour across diverse contexts, as evidenced by recent studies (Farrukh et al., 2022; Savari & Khaleghi, 2023). This study employs TPB due to its comprehensive approach to understanding human behaviour and its demonstrated effectiveness in predicting behavioural intentions. Unlike models such as the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT), which primarily focus on technology acceptance, TPB was developed to examine human behaviour in a broader range of contexts (Rejali et al., 2023; Rondan-Cataluña et al., 2015).

While TAM and UTAUT effectively capture factors like perceived usefulness and social influence in technology adoption, TPB provides a more comprehensive framework for understanding the cognitive and psychological aspects of behaviour (Rahman et al., 2017). This makes TPB particularly valuable for analysing not only technology-related behaviours but also public decision-making processes.

Governance regimes are broadly defined as the systems of rules, norms, and practices that shape how authority is exercised and decisions within institutions or societies (Benedict, 2001; Styhre, 2018). These regimes play a critical role in shaping decision-making processes by fostering transparency, accountability, and ethical standards, which are essential for building trust and positive attitudes towards technological innovations (OECD, 2024; Okada & Samreth, 2024).

In the context of technology adoption, governance regimes establish policies and regulatory frameworks that ensure technologies like AI align with societal values, norms, and ethical considerations (Alajmi et al., 2023; OECD, 2024). The integration of governance regimes with TPB provides a more holistic understanding of how institutional factors interact with psychological processes to influence behavioural outcomes.

Moreover, empirical studies have consistently shown that TPB often outperforms other models in explaining behavioural intentions, due to its ability to capture complex psychological processes, further validating its applicability to this research (Rahman et al., 2017; Rejali et al., 2023). The versatility and depth of TPB make it an ideal choice for exploring the complex mechanisms underlying human decision-making in various domains.

2.1. Positive attitude (PA)

More favourable attitudes towards a specific behaviour increases the likelihood of an individual intending to engage in that behaviour (Ajzen, 2020; Armitage & Conner, 2001). When it comes to AI technology, studies reveal that positive attitudes are a driving force behind its adoption (Cao et al., 2021; Wang et al., 2021). Moreover, a positive attitude indicates that people not only accept the technology but also expect it to minimise risks, ensure transparency, and uphold ethical standards (Díaz-Rodríguez et al., 2023; Felzmann et al., 2020). This positive outlook encourages individuals to support local government responsible AI practices that align with their values (Radanliev et al., 2024). For instance, Roberts et al.'s (2020) study found that stakeholders with favourable attitudes toward biotechnology were more likely to support a responsible innovation framework.

Local governments which are deeply embedded in citizens' everyday lives (Adilla et al., 2022; Ho, 2002), are increasingly integrating AI into essential services, from public safety and waste management to urban planning and social services (Yigitcanlar, Agdas, & Degirmenci, 2023; Yigitcanlar, David, et al., 2024). This integration requires a flexible and responsive governance approach to address the evolving challenges of AI (Taeihagh, 2021). When AI technologies are perceived to improve public services while adhering to responsible practices—such as transparency, fairness, and accountability—they serve as visible measures of the technology's value (Bracci, 2023).

As citizens' attitudes toward AI become more positive, their willingness to support responsible AI practices grows, highlighting the critical link between public perception and the adoption of responsible AI practices (Mikalef et al., 2022). Thus, we posit that public attitudes not only reflect general perceptions of AI technology but also drive the intention to support responsible AI practices. Therefore, we hypothesise:

H1. Positive public attitudes will increase intentions to support local government responsible AI practices.

2.2. Subjective norm (SN)

Close relationships—such as those with family, friends, neighbours, and co-workers—are powerful determinants of individual behaviour (Chiu et al., 2018). These influences, collectively referred to as subjective norms, have been shown to positively impact behavioural intentions across various emerging technological contexts, including e-learning, patent applications, and drone food delivery (Brettel et al., 2013; Chu & Chen, 2016; Kim & Hwang, 2020).

When it comes to AI, subjective norms can play an even more pronounced role due to the technology's complexity and societal implications. For instance, Sohn and Kwon (2020) stated that subjective norms significantly influence consumer decisions regarding AI-based intelligent products. Individuals, especially those without practical AI experience, are more likely to rely on the opinions of others when deciding whether to adopt AI solutions.

In the local government context, subjective norms may play an even more critical role (Sawaneh et al., 2024). Citizens often look to community leaders and local officials for cues on how to respond to technological advancements, particularly in complex areas such as AI (Cook & Sutherland, 2014; Robinson, 2020). This multi-level influence highlights the importance of diverse perspectives in shaping public opinion and decision-making processes (Nishii & Leroy, 2022).

Recent failures in local AI deployment, caused by a lack of ethics and transparency, have further embedded responsible AI practices in societal values (Rakova et al., 2021). These norms now shape individual AI usage expectation and behaviours (Sohn & Kwon, 2020). While some studies suggest the influence of subjective norms may decline as individuals gain more direct experience with technology (Dong et al., 2023), the rapidly evolving nature of AI ensures that social influence will remain a significant factor in AI adoption (Sadriwala & Dadhich, 2024; Sohn & Kwon, 2020). Therefore, as the use of AI in local governance expands (Yigitcanlar, David, et al., 2024), the influence of subjective norms on public intentions regarding responsible AI practices is expected to strengthen. Therefore, we hypothesise:

H2. Subjective norms will increase public intentions to support for local government responsible AI practices.

2.3. Perceived behavioural control (BC)

The more individuals feel informed and equipped with opportunities, the more inclined they are to act (Koellinger et al., 2007). Research indicates that individuals who feel a greater sense of control over AI technologies are more inclined to adopt them. For instance, Mohr and Kühl (2021) found that farmers' perceived ability to understand and interact with AI systems positively correlated with their intention to use AI in agriculture. Similarly, (Sadriwala & Dadhich, 2024) identified that higher behavioural control led to an increased willingness to adopt AI in small and medium industries.

As AI systems become increasingly integrated into local governance, citizen perceptions of their ability to understand, control, and engage with these technologies play a crucial role (Sartori & Theodorou, 2022). Local governments are adopting iterative and flexible strategies to educate the public, such as implementing AI ambassador programs that provide continuous training, creating pilot projects with built-in feedback mechanisms, and establishing transparent communication channels (Mikhaylov et al., 2018).

For instance, municipalities like Buenos Aires form cross-sectoral task forces to ensure responsible AI implementation and public understanding (Johns Hopkins University, 2024). These initiatives not only empower individuals but also enable a continuous feedback loop between citizens and policymakers, fostering trust and adaptability in the deployment of AI systems (Berryhill et al., 2019; Charles et al., 2022).

By fostering this sense of agency, citizens become more inclined to endorse and adopt these technologies (Gesk & Leyer, 2022; Yigitcanlar et al., 2022). This approach to public engagement and education highlights the critical need to examine how perceived behavioural control influences their intentions toward supporting responsible AI practices. This is vital because it's not just about adopting the technology, but also about ensuring that responsible practices are embedded within it to safeguard individuals from the potential risks of AI (Díaz-Rodríguez et al., 2023). Therefore, we hypothesise:

H3. Higher perceived behavioural control will increase public intentions to support responsible AI practices.

2.4. Perceived risk (PR)

Perceived risk is the possible adverse effects that individuals associate with a specific behaviour or technology (Lee, 2009; Martins et al., 2014). Higher perceived risks negatively impact intentions to adopt technologies (Pan et al., 2018; Sharma et al., 2020). In the context of AI, these risks can be multifaceted, encompassing concerns about privacy, job displacement, and ethical implications (Osasona et al., 2024). This is more pronounced at the local government level due to the direct impact on citizens' lives, the potential for bias and discrimination, privacy concerns, limited resources for oversight, and the need for context-specific decision-making (Mikalef et al., 2019). Studies show that individuals who perceive higher risks in using emerging technologies are often more inclined to seek solutions or practices that minimise these risks (Roca et al., 2017).

In the AI context, responsible AI practices are specifically designed to address and mitigate the risks associated with AI (Jobin et al., 2019). Therefore, when individuals perceive significant risks related to AI—whether through potential biases, lack of transparency, or misuse of data—this can create a heightened awareness of the need to support responsible AI practices (Werder et al., 2022; Wong, Tan, et al., 2022).

Investigating this at the local government level is crucial, as the proximity of AI applications to citizens' daily lives intensifies the need for responsible practices to mitigate risks, ensure trust, and safeguard public interests. Hence, we hypothesise:

H4. Higher levels of perceived risk will positively influence the intentions to support local government responsible AI practices.

2.5. Policy awareness (AW)

AI policy awareness refers to the extent to which citizens are informed about and understand specific policies implemented by governments, organisations, or institutions (Cerruti et al., 2023; Li et al., 2019). This awareness includes knowledge of existing regulations, guidelines, and ethical frameworks that govern AI usage in public services (Hsu et al., 2022; Saheb, 2024). In recent years, local governments have actively sought to develop their own policies to ensure the effective integration of responsible practices into AI systems, thereby directly benefits and safeguards their communities (Brandusescu, 2021). For instance, the AI registry of the city of Amsterdam, launched in 2020, provides citizens with transparent information about AI systems used in the city, fostering trust and encouraging responsible use (Municipality of Amsterdam, 2025).

Research across various fields—cybersecurity (Li et al., 2019; Wong, Lee, et al., 2022), environmental policies (Khatibi et al., 2021; Sarti & St, 2019), and private/public sector governance (Cunico et al., 2021)—suggests that policy awareness significantly influences individual compliance behaviours and perceptions of risk. For example, Li et al. (2019) found that employees who were well-informed about their organisation's information security policies demonstrated stronger risk management skills. This finding underscores the role of policy awareness in shaping individuals' competency and engagement with complex technologies.

Similarly, high awareness of AI policies can enhance citizen understanding of how AI systems operate and the ethical implications of their use (Robinson, 2020). This increased understanding can reduce perceived risks associated with AI, increasing willingness to engage with these technologies responsibly (Sohn & Kwon, 2020). Building on this evidence, we propose that heightened awareness of AI policies not only improves public understanding but also fosters greater support for responsible AI adoption. Therefore, we hypothesise:

H5. High AI policy awareness increases the intention to support local government responsible AI practices.

Meanwhile, policy awareness can lead to behavioural changes by influencing how people view and engage with the behaviour (Moloney et al., 2010; Strassheim, 2019). This indicates that when individuals understand the policies governing AI, their perceptions of the technology and its implications shift significantly (Li et al., 2019).

Nonetheless, it is important to note that the moderating effect of policy awareness may vary depending on factors such as policy complexity, individual differences in policy interpretation, and the specific context of application (Cerna, 2013; George et al., 2015). In some cases, increased policy awareness might even lead to heightened concerns or confusion if policies are perceived as inadequate or overly complex (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015; May, 1992). However, understanding the moderating role of AI policy awareness is crucial for local governments as it can inform strategies for policy communication, public engagement, and AI literacy initiatives (PytlikZillig & Tomkins, 2011; Vesnic-Alujevic et al., 2020). Thus, this study focused on whether local government AI policy awareness moderates the public's intention to support responsible AI practices. Therefore, we hypothesise:

H6a. AI policy awareness moderates the relationship between attitudes and support for local government responsible AI practices.

H6b. AI policy awareness moderates the relationship between subjective norms and support for local government responsible AI practices.

H6c. AI policy awareness moderates the relationship between behavioural control and support for local government responsible AI practices.

H6d. AI policy awareness moderates the relationship between perceived risk and support for local government responsible AI practices.

2.6. Policy expectation (EX)

The relationship between awareness and expectations is complex and multifaceted (Alhelaly et al., 2023; Sarra et al., 2020). As citizens become more aware of policies, their expectations regarding these policies may evolve (Bram, 2023). For instance, findings from Cerruti et al. (2023) indicate that individuals who are aware of policies related to vehicle choices develop heightened expectations regarding the role of fiscal incentives in their investment decisions.

The excitement surrounding AI can lead to unrealistic expectations, create unnecessary obstacles, and foster the misconception that AI is a cure-all, rather than recognising it as a tool that can facilitate positive outcomes (Berryhill et al., 2019). This expectation shift places pressure on local authorities to ensure that AI policies align with citizens' values (Robinson, 2020). If these AI policies fail to meet citizen expectations, it can lead to a breakdown of trust between communities and local authorities (Mikhaylov et al., 2018; Vogl, 2021). Such erosion of trust creates significant barriers to effective AI technology adoption, as communities may become hesitant to embrace innovations perceived as inadequately regulated or governed (Alhosani & Alhashmi, 2024; O'Shaughnessy et al., 2023).

Local governments play a pivotal role in fostering awareness through educational initiatives that clarify AI policies' objectives, benefits, and limitations (Noordt et al., 2023). By empowering citizens with knowledge about both the technical aspects and ethical implications of AI (Drobotowicz et al., 2023; Luusua & Ylipulli, 2021), local authorities can help align public expectations with governmental actions. In this context, comprehending the dynamics between policy awareness and public expectations becomes critical for facilitating smoother AI policy adoption. Therefore, we hypothesise:

H7. Higher AI policy awareness increases AI policy expectations.

A robust intention to pursue a specific behaviour influences expectations regarding that behaviour (Ajzen, 2011). When individuals are committed to acting in a certain way, they are likely to expect enabling environment that reinforce their motivations, thereby increasing the likelihood of engaging in that behaviour (Webb & Sheeran, 2006). For instance, Gadenne et al. (2011) found that when individuals are more likely to engage in sustainable practices, such as recycling and reducing waste, they expect their governments to uphold high environmental standards. In the context of AI adoption, individuals increasingly express a strong intention to support responsible AI practices (Alzebda & Matar, 2024; Shneiderman, 2020).

Consequently, their expectations for AI policies become more pronounced and specific (Robinson, 2020), particularly at the local level where the impact of AI implementation is often most directly felt (Adilla et al., 2022; Ho, 2002). For example, citizens may intend to support ethical oversight, the promotion of fairness, and assurances that AI systems are free from bias (Robinson, 2020; Schmager et al., 2024). These heightened intentions reflect a collective demand for policies that align with their values and support the responsible use of technology. Therefore, we hypothesise:

H8. The intention to adopt responsible AI practices increases the expectation regarding the AI policy.

The proposed research model and hypotheses are shown in Fig. 1.

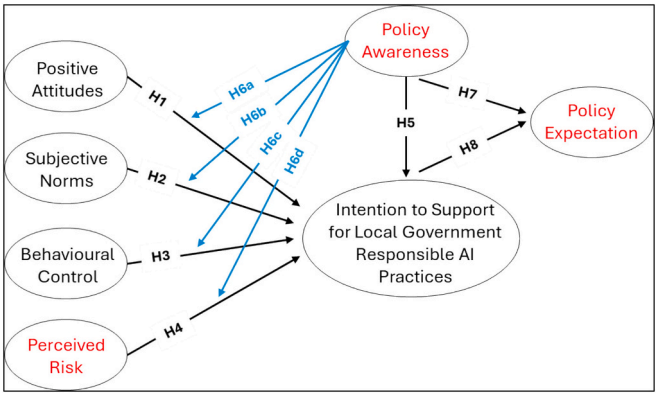

Fig. 1. Proposed research model and hypotheses

3. Research design

3.1. Survey locations

The Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD.AI, 2021) identified the US, the UK, Australia and Spain as the countries with highest government related AI policy initiatives countries. Among them, the US, Australia, and Spain have been selected as survey areas for investigating the factors associating with intention to support responsible AI practices adopted by local government.

Governments play a crucial role in shaping AI policies through their governance regimes, which define the regulatory frameworks, institutional structures, and policy approaches guiding AI adoption (Dixon, 2023; Palladino, 2022). These governance structures vary significantly between national and local levels, influencing how AI policies are developed, communicated, and adopted (Filgueiras, 2022). Understanding these governance differences is essential for interpreting variations in public AI policy awareness and expectations across these countries.

3.1.1. United States

The US operates under a federal system in which authority is constitutionally divided among federal, state, and local governments. Local governments—including cities, towns, and townships—are responsible for a wide range of public services such as public safety, transportation, housing, and emergency response. This layer of government is highly diverse, encompassing both large urban centres and small rural communities, which leads to significant variation in capacity and priorities when adopting emerging technologies like AI (The White House, 2025).

The US has been key innovators and early adopters of AI, leveraging their operational flexibility and close ties to community needs (Neumann et al., 2022). For instance, Pittsburgh uses AI to manage traffic flow and identify homes with high lead concentrations in tap water (Hajiseyedjavadi et al., 2020; Pillai, 2024), while Phoenix's myPHX311 platform enables residents to access services and report issues efficiently (City of Phoenix, 2021) and Boston use AI for traffic light management (City of Boston, 2024).

At the federal level, agencies such as the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) provide guidance through resources like the 2024 AI Risk Management Framework (NIST, 2023; Tabassi, 2023). While these frameworks offer important structure, they are non-binding, meaning local governments are not required to adopt them. As a result, a patchwork of AI policies has emerged across the country (NIST, 2023). Unlike centralised governance systems, the US local governments often operate with significant autonomy—many under home rule provisions—which enables them to independently develop AI policies (Taylor, 2014). This decentralisation has resulted in a wide spectrum of AI maturity levels and ethical standards across municipalities. In response to their specific needs and priorities, cities such as New York, Tempe, and Lebanon have each introduced their own AI use policies, illustrating the diverse approaches emerging at the local level.

Recent national initiatives have further shaped the local AI landscape. President Biden's 2023 executive order outlined principles for trustworthy AI, and in 2025, a $500 billion private sector investment was announced to bolster AI infrastructure (Holland, 2025; The White House, 2023). These developments have catalysed local action, with cities such as San Jose leading collaborative efforts through initiatives like the GovAI Coalition—a network supporting municipalities in developing responsible AI standards and tools (City of San José, 2024).

These dynamics highlight the importance of including the US in this study—not only for its national AI strategy but also for the rich, varied, and increasingly influential role of local governments in shaping AI governance.

3.1.2. Australia

Australia operates under a federal system in which powers are divided between the Commonwealth (federal), state and territory, and local governments. Local governments—comprising councils in cities, towns, and shires—are established under state and territory legislation and are responsible for delivering a wide range of community services (Australian Electoral Commission, 2024). While they do not have constitutional status (Phillimore et al., 2022), local governments play a critical role in service delivery and are increasingly engaging with digital transformation initiatives, including AI. Since local governments are created under state law, the degree of autonomy, resourcing, and capacity to experiment with digital technologies—including AI—can vary significantly across jurisdictions.

Australia's AI governance regime stands out for its collaborative, principle-driven approach that emphasises ethics, transparency, and risk assurance. Based on Australia's AI Ethics Principles, the National Framework for the Assurance of AI in Government, agreed upon in 2024, provides a nationally consistent strategy for the safe and responsible use of AI across all levels of government (Australian Government, 2024; Digital Transformation Agency, 2024a). These federal frameworks offer valuable alignment and guidance for councils aiming to integrate AI responsibly (Digital Transformation Agency, 2024b).

Although AI use at the local government level is still emerging, some councils have begun exploring AI for tasks such as traffic signal optimisation, waste collection route planning, and customer service automation. For example, Brimbank City Council uses AI to identify roadside assets requiring maintenance and enhance asset management efficiency (Kang et al., 2023), while Logan City Council has explored AI applications for improving city safety (City of Logan, 2025). Additionally, councils such as Ipswich, Clarence Valley, Warrnambool, and the District Council of Streaky Bay have released policy documents aligned with Australia's AI Ethics Principles, demonstrating how national guidelines can influence local-level practice.

Regarding budget allocation, it reflects disparities. In the 2025–26 Federal Budget, local governments received $3.45 billion in Financial Assistance Grants, representing approximately 0.51 % of Commonwealth taxation revenue (Australian Local Government Association, 2025). These untied grants allow councils to address local priorities such as infrastructure development and community services. However, funding challenges persist, with calls for increased support for AI-related initiatives at the municipal level (Australian Local Government Association, 2025; CPA Australia, 2018). Programs like the NSW Early Adopter Grant have provided targeted funding to trial AI technologies in planning systems, helping smaller councils overcome financial and technical barriers (O'Donnell, 2024).

The Australian context provides useful insights into how coordinated policy frameworks, clear ethical guidelines, and intergovernmental collaboration can support responsible and effective AI integration at the local government level—while also highlighting the importance of tailoring support to accommodate the uneven capacity and autonomy of

councils across the country.

3.1.3. Spain

Spain's governance system is defined by a parliamentary constitutional monarchy with significant powers devolved to autonomous communities and municipalities (Council of European Municipalities and Regions, 2025). Local governments in Spain enjoy a degree of autonomy (Navarro & Pano, 2022) that enables them to develop and implement their own strategies for technological advancement.

Spain stands out as a representative model of EU AI policy and governance. The creation of the Spanish Agency for AI Supervision (AESIA)—Europe's first dedicated AI regulatory authority—ensures that Spain is at the forefront of implementing the EU AI Act and setting rigorous standards for ethical, inclusive, and beneficial AI (European Commission, 2022). However, larger cities such as Barcelona and Madrid have developed their own AI and data governance strategies, often supported by dedicated innovation departments or public-private partnerships. For example, Barcelona City Council collaborated with Microsoft and Municipal Institution of Information Technology to improve the productivity within the council (Barcelona City Council, 2025), while Madrid has explored AI for predictive policing and traffic optimisation (Moral-Carcedo, 2024).

Smaller municipalities, however, often face challenges in adopting AI due to limited technical expertise, budget constraints, and fragmented digital infrastructure. To address these disparities, regional governments and inter-municipal consortia have played a key role in supporting local digital transformation. Initiatives such as the Red Española de Ciudades Inteligentes (RECI) and funding from the EU's NextGenerationEU recovery plan have provided resources and technical guidance for AI experimentation at the local level (Lilyanova, 2024).

Spain's National AI Strategy, introduced in December 2020, takes a multidisciplinary approach to address economic, social, environmental, and governance challenges (Government of Spain, 2020). This is complemented by the Spanish Digital Agenda 2025 and the AI Strategy 2024–2025, which allocates €1.5 billion to consolidate and expand AI use throughout the economy and public administration (Quathem & Valat, 2023; Spanish Government, 2023). Spain has also set up the EU's first regulatory sandbox for AI, allowing for the testing of AI applications in a controlled environment (Spanish Government, 2023). Programs like this help bridge the gap between national policy and local implementation, enabling municipalities to participate in AI innovation (Marcucci et al., 2022).

Spain's combination of strong local government autonomy, pioneering national regulatory institutions, and alignment with the EU's comprehensive AI framework makes it an ideal context for studying the adoption, governance, and societal impact of AI at the local level.

3.2. Survey design

The survey was crafted using the research framework illustrated in Fig. 1. Drawing on the existing literature in the fields of AI and the TPB, validated questions and indices were created. Contextual adjustments were made to ensure the relevance of the items to public awareness and to the expectations regarding local government AI policies. A panel of professors and doctoral candidates evaluated the items for clarity and comprehensibility, ensuring they were user-friendly. Further refinements were made with input from doctoral candidates across various disciplines, broadening the survey's accessibility to a wider audience.

To ensure a shared understanding of AI, the definition of AI was provided to participants in the introduction of the survey. This ensured that all respondents were aligned in their understanding of the term, particularly in the context of local government.

To assess respondents' positive attitude toward AI in local government, six statements highlighting the benefits of AI applications were used. Subjective norms were measured by evaluating the extent to which social influences shape public attitudes toward AI adoption. Perceived behavioural control captured the degree to which individuals feel they have control over their engagement with AI in local government services.

Perceived risk reflected public concerns regarding AI implementation, assessed through six risk-related factors. AI policy awareness was measured using a set of survey questions designed to capture respondents' knowledge, engagement, and understanding of local government AI policy initiatives. AI policy expectations represented public anticipation of how local governments should develop AI policies to ensure responsible AI adoption. Finally, the intention to support responsible AI practices was assessed by evaluating respondents' stance on various responsible AI characteristics within local government settings.

The study employed a 5-point Likert scale, with a completion time of just 15 min to enhance convenience for respondents. Detailed descriptions of the measurement items and their reference sources can be found in Appendix A.

3.3. Data

The survey was conducted using the Prolific platform—i.e., Prolific (https://www.prolific.com/). The survey was designed in Qualtrics (https://www.qualtrics.com), known for its robust features that enable the creation of customised questionnaires (Litman et al., 2016). This study leveraged the capabilities of both Qualtrics and Prolific to facilitate survey design and data collection across multiple countries.

Eligible participants in this study were adults (≥18 years) from the general public across three countries. Additionally, Prolific provided the ability to ensure an appropriate gender proportion for each country, further enhancing the representativeness of the sample. The minimum required sample size was determined using the single proportion formula (Israel, 1992), based on a 95 % confidence level and a 5 % margin of error. The calculated minimum sample size was 384 participants. In total, 1220 valid responses were collected from the three countries and used for empirical analysis.

While efforts were made to achieve balanced representation across countries, there was an overrepresentation of participants from Spain. This variation reflects differences in response rates and participant availability during the survey period. The implications of this overrepresentation are further discussed in the limitations section. The demographic statistics of the respondents are presented in Table 1.

The survey results showed that 98.69 % of respondents were familiar with AI technology, ranging from basic awareness to in-depth knowledge, while only 1.31 % reported no familiarity at all. This diverse range of AI familiarity among participants allows for a comprehensive exploration the study aim.

4. Analysis and results

Structural Equation Modelling (SEM) was employed for data analysis to simultaneously examine complex relationships between multiple latent constructs (Deng et al., 2018; Marsh et al., 2014). SEM also accounts for measurement error and allows for the testing of both direct and indirect effects within the model (Cheung & Cheung, 2016). The study utilised the two-stage SEM methodology recommended by Anderson and Gerbing (1988).

First measurement models were estimated, and assessed for their discriminant and convergent validity, as well as reliability. Subsequently, the study's hypotheses were tested using a comprehensive structural model. Data analysis was conducted using RStudio version 4.4.1. with the 'Lavaan' package.

4.1. Measurement model testing

Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) was performed to identify indicators significantly associated with their respective latent construct.

Table 1
Respondents demographic background.

Characteristics	Category	USA		Australia		Spain		Total	
		Frequency	%	Frequency	%	Frequency	%	Frequency	%
Gender	Male	210	54.55 *(49.4)*	166	42.78 *(49.6)*	192	42.95 *(49)*	568	46.56
	Female	171	44.42 *(50.5)*	218	56.19 *(50.3)*	248	55.48 *(51)*	637	52.21
	Other	4	1.04	4	1.03	7	1.57	15	1.23
Age	18–24	63	16.36	83	21.39	74	16.55	220	18.03
	25–34	137	35.58	136	35.05	179	40.04	452	37.05
	35–44	88	22.86	104	26.80	107	23.94	299	24.51
	45–54	65	16.88	49	12.63	59	13.20	173	14.18
	55–64	24	6.23	13	3.35	20	4.47	57	4.67
	65–74	7	1.82	2	0.52	8	1.79	17	1.39
	>75	1	0.26	1	0.26	0	0.00	2	0.16
Education level	Primary education or below	1	0.26	1	0.26	3	0.67	5	0.41
	Secondary education	43	11.17	72	18.56	113	25.28	228	18.69
	Associate degree or vocational certificate	47	12.21	60	15.46	72	16.11	179	14.67
	Bachelor's degree	159	41.30	190	48.97	179	40.04	528	43.28
	Master's degree	118	30.65	54	13.92	63	14.09	235	19.26
	Doctoral degree or above	16	4.16	7	1.80	10	2.24	33	2.70
	Other	1	0.26	4	1.03	7	1.57	12	0.98
Annual income	No income	35	9.09	20	5.15	30	6.71	85	6.97
	Low income	81	21.04	96	24.74	108	24.16	285	23.36
	Medium-low income	91	23.64	92	23.71	122	27.29	305	25.00
	Medium income	138	35.84	133	34.28	133	29.75	404	33.11
	Medium-high income	37	9.61	43	11.08	47	10.51	127	10.41
	High income	3	0.78	4	1.03	7	1.57	14	1.15

Note: *Figures in the brackets represent the census data of gender ratio.*

These indicators were then used to estimate the measurement models. This methodology aligns with established practices in the field (Cheung et al., 2024; Luong & Flake, 2022).

4.1.1. *Measurement model fit*

To ensure a good fit, measurement model was refined according to several indices. Following MacCallum et al. (1992), path estimates ($\Lambda < 0.50$, $p > 0.05$), squared multiple correlations ($R^2 < 0.50$), and modification indices (M.I. > 10) were used to identify areas for improvement.

Table 2
Measuring model testing results.

Latent variable	Item	Mean	Standard deviation (SD)	Factor loading (FL) >0.5	Cronbach's alpha (CA) >0.7	Omega composite reliability (CR) >0.7	Average variance extracted (AVE) >0.5
Positive attitude	PA1	2.389	1.041	0.682	0.899	0.900	0.602
	PA 2	2.150	1.079	0.761			
	PA 3	1.583	1.084	0.788			
	PA 4	1.668	1.139	0.792			
	PA 5	1.793	1.128	0.810			
	PA 6	1.768	1.128	0.803			
Subjective norm	SN1	1.180	1.187	0.959	0.876	0.877	0.781
	SN2	1.350	1.293	0.815			
Behavioural control	BC1	2.704	1.102	0.813	0.726	0.734	0.582
	BC1	3.066	1.036	0.702			
Perceived Risk	PR2	2.800	1.026	0.739	0.826	0.828	0.593
	PR3	2.764	1.036	0.626			
	PR4	2.966	1.003	0.665			
	PR5	2.670	1.137	0.716			
	PR6	2.752	1.062	0.753			
Awareness of local government AI policy	AW1	1.236	1.113	0.706	0.723	0.729	0.573
	AW3	1.038	1.107	0.760			
	AW4	0.524	0.956	0.609			
Expectation of local government AI policy	EX1	2.593	1.110	0.643	0.833	0.832	0.556
	EX2	2.758	1.042	0.668			
	EX3	2.907	0.885	0.838			
	EX4	3.320	0.911	0.837			
Adoption of responsible AI practices	RAI1	3.519	0.762	0.677	0.897	0.896	0.541
	RAI3	3.157	0.974	0.584			
	RAI4	3.157	0.974	0.599			
	RAI7	3.016	0.918	0.641			
	RAI8	3.463	0.801	0.711			
	RAI9	3.256	0.901	0.728			
	RAI10	3.106	0.898	0.736			
	RAI11	3.261	0.828	0.716			
	RAI12	2.889	1.051	0.614			
	RAI13	3.248	0.863	0.723			
	RAI15	3.234	0.916	0.622			

As a result, some indices were removed, especially, one from the subjective norm (SN) scale, one from perceived risk (PR), one from the awareness of local government AI policy (AW) scale, and four from the adoption of responsible AI practices (RAI) scale.

After these modifications, it was reassessed whether the model was fit. The fit indices—root means square error of approximation (RMSEA = 0.053) < 0.07 (Hair Jr. et al., 2010), the standardised root mean square residual (SRMR = 0.048) < 0.08 (Hu & Bentler, 1999), the Tucker–Lewis Index (TLI = 0.900) > 0.90, the comparative fit index (CFI = 0.910) > 0.90 (Hu & Bentler, 1999; Kim et al., 2016)—met the recommended thresholds, confirming that the model exhibited a good fit to the data.

4.1.2. Reliability and validity of measurement model

Reliability and validity tests were performed to ensure the robustness of the measurement model (Clark & Watson, 2019; Farooq, 2016). Reliability was evaluated using Cronbach's alpha (CA) and composite reliability (CR), with CA measuring internal consistency within constructs and CR assessing the collective representation of items for their respective constructs (Carmines & Zeller, 1979).

The assessment of validity involved a thorough examination of both convergent and discriminant validity. Convergent validity was determined by analysing factor loadings (FL) and average variance extracted (AVE), which reflect how well the items correspond to their respective constructs (Jackson, 1969). Acceptable thresholds were set at CA > 0.5, CR > 0.7, and FL and AVE > 0.5 (Hulland, 1999). The results are shown in Table 2.

To assess discriminant validity, the Fornell-Larcker criterion was utilised, which involves comparing the square root of the Average Variance Extracted (AVE) for each construct against its correlations with other constructs (Hulland, 1999). Table 3 presents these results, with the diagonal values representing AVE square roots (in bold) and off-diagonal values showing inter-construct correlations. Each construct's AVE square root exceeded its correlations, establishing discriminant validity (Hair et al., 2019).

Significant collinearity can bias path coefficients (Hair et al., 2012). The variance inflation factor (VIF) must be calculated to avoid collinearity issues. The VIF values for all constructs range from 1.036 to 2.091, remaining well below the threshold of 3. This confirms that there is no evidence of collinearity among the constructs (Hair et al., 2012).

4.2. Structural model testing

Initially, demographic variables (age, gender, income, and education) were included in the structural model to evaluate their potential moderating effects. However, since these factors did not significantly influence the relationships among constructs, they were removed from the final model to focus on the primary relationships of interest. A robust bootstrapping technique was employed for hypothesis testing. 5000 resamples generated with a 95 % confidence interval to assess the stability and reliability of model estimates (Nevitt & Hancock, 2001; Streukens & Leroi-Werelds, 2016).

The results are presented in Fig. 2 depicting the structural relationships between the constructs. Table 4 provides a detailed breakdown of path coefficients, including estimates, standard errors, Z-values, and significance levels for each hypothesised relationship (i.e., positive attitude had a significantly positive association towards support for responsible AI practices ($\beta = 0.132$, Z value = 5.082, $p < 0.001$); thus, H1 was supported; The relationship between subjective norm and support for responsible AI practices was not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.013$, Z value = 0.678, $p > 0.05$); thus, H2 was rejected.

The analysis reveals critical insights into the support for responsible AI practices. Notably, perceived risk emerges as a strong predictor, with a substantial estimate (0.301) indicating that heightened awareness of AI risks is associated with greater individual engagement in responsible behaviours. Positive attitude (0.132) and policy awareness (0.143) also show a positive relationship, indicating that a favourable attitude and awareness of policies are linked to enhanced responsible AI engagement.

Conversely, subjective norms do not demonstrate a significant relationship with support, suggesting that social influences may be less relevant in this context. Interestingly, policy awareness shows a negative relationship with policy expectations (−0.026), indicating that greater awareness is not necessarily associated with heightened expectations for robust policies. Additionally, a strong positive link exists between the support of responsible AI practices and policy expectations (0.762), suggesting that responsible engagement is closely linked with demands for effective AI policies. These findings highlight the complex interplay of attitudes, awareness, and expectations in shaping responsible AI practices.

An indirect effects analysis was also conducted to examine relationships between variables through mediators (Nitzl et al., 2016; Preacher & Kelley, 2011). The results, detailed in Table 5, reveal significant associations between local government AI policy awareness and responsible AI practice. It shows a significant positive association with positive attitude, which, in turn, facilitates support for responsible AI practices.

Furthermore, increased policy awareness is associated with greater recognition of perceived risk, suggesting that well-informed individuals are more attuned to the potential risks associated with AI technologies. In contrast, subjective norms demonstrate no statistically significant relationship with the outcome variables. Additionally, behavioural control shows a modest positive association. These patterns highlight the potential value of policy awareness as a correlate of positive attitudes and ensuring responsible AI adoption, ultimately leading to safer and more ethical AI practices.

4.3. Comparative analysis

The results of the Kruskal-Wallis test reveal statistically significant differences in the descriptive statistics among the three samples, highlighting the need for a comparative analysis. Tables 6 and 7 present the significance levels for the hypothesised direct and indirect path relationships across the countries under study.

An analysis of direct paths reveals that positive attitude shows a strong positive association across all three countries, with coefficients of 0.163 for Australia, 0.156 for the USA, and 0.109 for Spain. Perceived Risk emerges as a strongest predictor, demonstrating the highest coefficients: 0.355 in Australia, 0.304 in the USA, and 0.248 in Spain. Policy Awareness also exhibits a positive relationship on adoption, particularly pronounced in Australia (0.231) and Spain (0.167), while showing a weaker association in the USA (0.112). Notably, subjective norms and behavioural control are not significant. The support for responsible AI practices is strongly associated with policy expectations across all three countries, suggesting the potential importance of public responsible engagement in shaping policy perceptions.

The indirect paths highlight that in Australia, the path from policy awareness to positive attitude shows a significant association with support for responsible AI practices (coefficient = 0.037), supporting hypothesis H6a. However, this relationship is not statistically supported in the USA and Spain. Conversely, perceived risk displays consistent associations across all countries, with coefficients of 0.082 in Australia,

Table 3
Fornell-Larcker discriminant validity testing.

	PA	SN	BC	PR	AW	EX	RAI
PA	**0.776**						
SN	0.281	**0.883**					
BC	0.206	0.096	**0.762**				
PR	−0.271	−0.082	0.057	**0.770**			
AW	0.406	0.629	0.066	−0.193	**0.756**		
EX	−0.011	−0.068	0.086	0.262	−0.150	**0.745**	
RAI	0.003	−0.083	0.150	0.436	−0.203	0.593	**0.735**

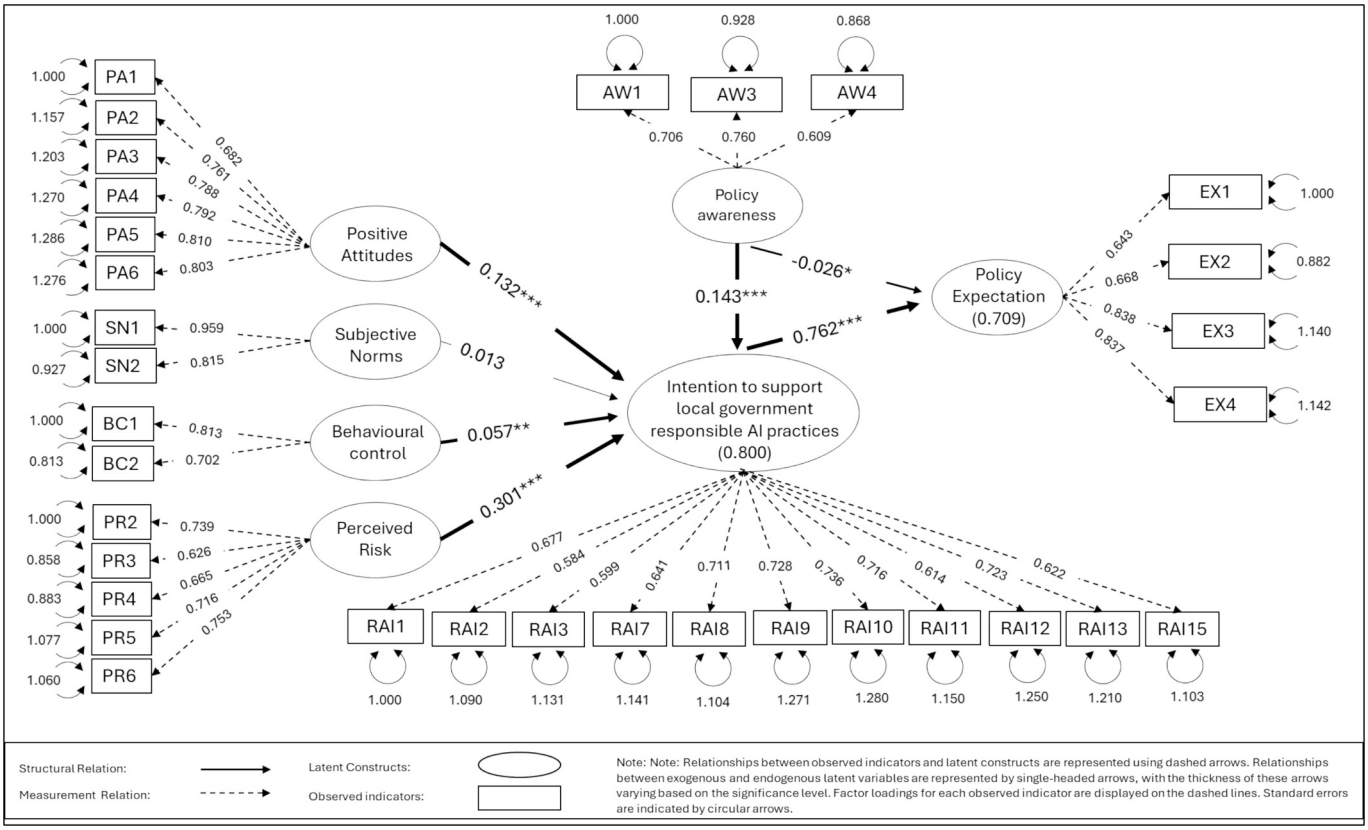

Fig. 2. Measurement and structural model as overall.
Note: PA = Positive attitude, SN = Subjective norm, BC = Behavioural control, PR = Perceived Risk, AW = Local government AI policy awareness, EX = Local government AI policy expectation, RAI = Responsible AI adoption, *P < 0.05, **P < 0.01, ***P < 0.001; Parentheses inside the constructs indicate the R^2 value.

0.034 in the USA, and 0.041 in Spain, indicating that heightened awareness of AI risks may correlate with responsible practices (H6d).

Other hypothesised paths, such as those from policy awareness through subjective norms or behavioural control, lack statistical support in all countries. This suggests that policy awareness does not appear to moderate support for responsible AI practice through these factors. These findings contribute to understanding the complex interplay of factors associated with support for responsible AI practices across different national contexts.

5. Findings and discussion

5.1. Core elements of theory of planned behaviour

5.1.1. Positive attitude: a consistent but varied influence

The analysis reveals associations between positive attitudes and support for responsible AI practices across the overall and country-specific models, as posited in Hypothesis 1. Nonetheless, the strength of this relationship varies, Australia (β = 0.163), USA (β = 0.156) and Spain (β = 0.109). These differences suggest that while positive attitudes toward AI are generally associated with responsible practices in local governments, the extent of this relationship may vary with contextual differences. Contextual differences refer to "recognising that social-group differences come from participating in and adapting to diverse sociocultural contexts" (Stephens et al., 2018).

These variations could stem from differences in AI governance structures, policy approaches, and sociocultural factors, which shape public engagement with responsible AI practices (O'Shaughnessy et al., 2023; Yigitcanlar, Li, et al., 2023). Australia's relatively stronger relationship between positive attitudes and responsible AI support may attributed to its well-established AI governance frameworks and sociocultural characteristics. As a WEIRD (Western, Educated, Industrialised, Rich, Democratic) nation, Australia emphasises individual agency and ethical reasoning in public discourse on technology (Henrich et al., 2010; James & Whelan, 2021).

A nationwide study conducted by Monash University, in collaboration with the Monash Data Futures Institute, revealed that Australians generally hold a positive view of the increasing integration of AI into society, indicating broad public support for its adoption. Also, citizens actively engage in shaping AI policies through consultations and advocacy efforts, reinforcing expectations of government transparency and accountability (Digital Transformation Agency, 2024c). National initiatives such as the Policy for the Responsible Use of AI and the Voluntary AI Safety Standard provide a clear ethical foundation for AI adoption, strengthening public trust and aligning positive attitudes with responsible AI practices (Department of Industry, Science and Resources, 2024).

In contrast, Spain's collectivist culture prioritises institutional trust and compliance with EU-aligned policies like the EU AI Act (Kaasa & Andriani, 2021; Sacristán-Navarro et al., 2022), which may limit grassroots engagement with AI ethics at the municipal level. Spain has demonstrated efforts to promote grassroots engagement in AI ethics at the municipal level. For example, Barcelona's Municipal Algorithms and Data Strategy incorporates citizen participation through advisory councils and public algorithm registries (Barcelona City Council, 2023).

These initiatives aim to align technological innovation with human-centered values, showcasing how local governments can bridge the gap between centralised policies and community involvement. However, such efforts are not uniformly distributed across Spain's 8131 municipalities, many of which lack the resources or expertise to implement similar strategies effectively (Martínez & Wissink, 2021). While Spain has introduced emerging AI ethical guidelines (Government of Spain,

Table 4
Direct path analysis and signification of the structural model – overall.

Hypothesis	Path	Estimates	Std. Err	Z value (P (>|z|))	Results
Direct path					
H1	Positive Attitude → Support for responsible AI practices	0.132	0.026	5.082***	Supported
H2	Subjective Norm → Support for responsible AI practices	0.013	0.019	0.678	Not Supported
H3	Behavioural Control → Support for responsible AI practices	0.057	0.020	2.872**	Supported
H4	Perceived Risk → Support for responsible AI practices	0.301	0.025	11.879***	Supported
H5	Policy Awareness → Support for responsible AI practices	0.143	0.033	4.359***	Supported
H7	Policy Awareness → Policy Expectation	−0.026	0.026	−1.009*	Not Supported
H8	Support for responsible AI practices → Policy Expectation	0.762	0.052	14.762***	Supported

* $P < 0.05$.
** $P < 0.01$.
*** $P < 0.001$.

Table 5
Indirect path analysis of structural model – overall.

Hypothesis	Path	Estimates	Std. Err	Z value (P (>|z|))	Results
Indirect path					
H6a	AW→PA → RAI	0.019	0.007	2.854**	Supported
H6b	AW→SN → RAI	0.002	0.003	0.610	Not Supported
H6c	AW→BC → RAI	0.008	0.003	2.448*	Supported
H6d	AW→PR → RAI	0.043	0.010	4.168***	Supported

Note: PA = Positive Attitude, SN = Subjective Norm, BC = Behavioural Control, PR = Perceived Risk, AW = local government AI policy awareness, EX = local government AI policy expectation, RAI = adoption responsible AI practices.
* $P < 0.05$.
** $P < 0.01$.
*** $P < 0.001$.

2024), the relatively recent nature of these efforts may contribute to the weaker influence of positive attitudes on responsible AI adoption. The top-down governance approach, while effective for policy implementation, may not yet foster the same level of public involvement seen in Australia.

The USA presents a different challenge, as its highly decentralised AI governance results in regulatory fragmentation across federal, state, and local levels (Davtyan, 2024). While federal initiatives promote "safe and trustworthy" AI systems, local governments vary significantly in their capacity to implement these ideals due to resource constraints and differing priorities (ICMA, 2024). Additionally, the USA's polarised sociopolitical landscape influences public trust in AI governance, where attitudes toward technology ethics reflect broader political divides (O'Shaughnessy et al., 2023). This fragmented regulatory environment sustains a moderate reliance on individual attitudes to bridge gaps between ethical principles and practical AI implementation.

5.1.2. *Subjective norms: an unexpected non-factor*

The non-significant relationship of subjective norms and support for responsible AI practices (β = 0.013) in the local government context is surprising and warrants deeper examination, as posited in Hypothesis 2. This finding challenges the traditional understanding of social influences on individuals' intention, particularly emerging technologies such as AI (To & Tang, 2018).

One possible explanation for this observation may lie in the complexity and novelty of AI technologies. Unlike more familiar policy areas, AI governance may be perceived as a highly specialised domain where individuals rely more on personal knowledge and direct experiences than social consensus (Kelly et al., 2022), particularly given the recency and emerging nature of AI technologies. This interpretation aligns with the TPB, which suggests that in situations of high uncertainty or complexity, personal attitudes and perceived behavioural control may take precedence over subjective norms (Ajzen, 1991).

5.1.3. *Behavioural control: a mixed picture*

The analysis reveals varying associations between behavioural control and support for responsible AI practices across different countries, as posited in Hypothesis 3. While the overall relationship shows a positive and statistically significant association (β = 0.057), country-specific analyses revealed divergent patterns. In Australia and the USA, the relationship was not statistically significant. In contrast, Spain demonstrated a significant positive relationship (β = 0.118). These findings suggest that while there is a general positive association between perceived behavioural control and support for responsible AI practices, this relationship is not uniformly strong across different local government contexts.

Spain, as a member of the European Union, benefits from the EU's comprehensive regulatory framework for AI, which includes the AI Act and the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) (Sartor et al., 2020). The EU's stringent rules around transparency, accountability, and fairness in AI might provide a stronger safety net for citizens, increasing their confidence and perceived control over the technology's adoption (Nannini et al., 2023). While Australia and the USA also have AI regulations, they may lack the same uniformity or comprehensive ethical mandates across all regions.

In Australia, while national initiatives like the Policy for Responsible Use of AI provide ethical guidelines, these frameworks rely heavily on voluntary compliance rather than enforceable mandates (Department of Industry, Science and Resource, 2023). This reliance on self-regulation may dilute citizens' perception of their ability to influence AI adoption directly. The USA's decentralised governance further exacerbates this issue.

Regulatory efforts vary widely across federal, state, and local levels due to its fragmented form of federalism (Feijóo et al., 2020; Zaidan & Ibrahim, 2024). While federal initiatives like the Blueprint for an AI Bill of Rights promote ethical principles such as algorithmic fairness and transparency, inconsistent implementation at lower levels creates disparities in public confidence regarding their ability to impact AI governance (Engler, 2022). Additionally, historical scepticism toward governmental institutions in the USA contributes to weaker perceptions of control over technological adoption (Ladd et al., 2023).

Cultural differences may also be associated with how people perceive behavioural control. Spain has a deeply rooted tradition of collectivism and community involvement, which may amplify individuals' belief in their ability to influence societal issues, including AI responsible practices (Cruz et al., 2022; Kitayama & Salvador, 2023). In Australia, while trust in government institutions is generally high, the population might

Table 6
Direct path analysis and signification of the structural model for Australia, USA and Spain.

Hypothesis	Path	Australia			USA			Spain		
		Estimates	Z value (P (>|z|))	Results	Estimates	Z value (P (>|z|))	Results	Estimates	Z value (P (>|z|))	Results
Direct Path										
H1	Positive Attitude → Support for responsible AI practices	0.163	3.834***	Supported	0.156	3.760***	Supported	0.109	1.921*	Supported
H2	Subjective Norm → Support for responsible AI practices	0.039	1.113	Not Supported	0.002	0.052	Not Supported	0.058	1.559	Not Supported
H3	Behavioural Control → Support for responsible AI practices	0.047	0.662	Not Supported	0.023	0.619	Not Supported	0.118	2.698**	Supported
H4	Perceived Risk → Support for responsible AI practices	0.355	8.768***	Supported	0.304	6.222***	Supported	0.248	5.528***	Supported
H5	Policy Awareness → Support for responsible AI practices	0.231	3.540***	Supported	0.112	2.333*	Supported	0.167	0.013**	Supported
H7	Policy Awareness → Policy Expectation	−0.015	−0.296	Not Supported	−0.025	−0.590	Not Supported	−0.012	0.007	Not Supported
H8	Support for responsible AI practices → Policy Expectation	0.552	10.272***	Supported	0.678	7.989***	Supported	0.603	7.600***	Supported

* $P < 0.05$.
** $P < 0.01$.
*** $P < 0.001$.

Table 7
Indirect path analysis of structural model for Australia, USA and Hong Kong.

Hypothesis	Path	Australia			USA			Spain		
		Estimates	Z value (P(>|z|))	Results	Estimates	Z value (P(>|z|))	Results	Estimates	Z value (P(>|z|))	Results
Indirect path										
H6a	AW→PA → RAI	0.037	2.240*	Supported	0.018	1.723	Not Supported	0.018	1.319	Not Supported
H6b	AW→SN → RAI	0.009	0.892	Not Supported	0.000	0.051	Not Supported	0.010	1.031	Not Supported
H6c	AW→BC → RAI	0.011	1.522	Not Supported	0.003	0.609	Not Supported	0.020	1.886	Not Supported
H6d	AW→PR → RAI	0.082	3.268*****	Supported	0.034	2.233*	Supported	0.041	2.387*	Supported

Note: PA = Positive Attitude, SN = Subjective Norm, BC = Behavioural Control, PR = Perceived Risk, AW = local government AI policy awareness, EX = local government AI policy expectation, RAI = adoption responsible AI practices.
* $P < 0.05$.
** $P < 0.01$.
*** $P < 0.001$.

view technological adoption as driven primarily by experts or the private sector, potentially reducing their sense of direct influence (Australian Public Service Commission, 2023; Blind, 2007). Meantime, public trust in institutions has historically been lower in the USA—especially regarding technology governance—further weakening perceptions of individual influence over AI practices (Partnership for Public Service, 2024).

5.2. Extension to the TPB model in AI governance

5.2.1. Perceived risk: a dominant factor

Perceived risk emerges as a significant predictor of support for responsible AI practices, with strong associations observed across all three countries: Australia (β = 0.355), the US (β = 0.304), and Spain (β = 0.248), supporting Hypothesis 4. This pattern suggests that individuals' concerns about the potential negative consequences of AI technologies are closely linked to their support for responsible practices.

Notably, perceived risk exhibits a stronger association compared to positive attitudes. This observation aligns with principles from prospect theory, which proposes that individuals tend to weigh potential losses more heavily than equivalent gains (Levy, 1992).

Recent AI-related incidents may contribute to this perception of heightened risk. For instance, the Robodebt scandal in Australia, where an automated debt recovery system incorrectly issued debt notices to welfare recipients, caused significant public distress (Braithwaite, 2020). In the US, cases of algorithmic bias have emerged, such as the Internal Revenue Service's AI system reportedly auditing Black taxpayers at three times the rate of other taxpayers due to systemic discrimination. Similarly, in California and Colorado, faulty algorithms led to the denial of Medicaid to pregnant women and foster children based on incorrect data and coding rules (AAAS, 2020).

While Spain has avoided prominent scandals like those in Australia or the US, concerns about privacy breaches under GDPR frameworks remain significant (DLA PIPER, 2024). However, studies have shown that the Covid-19 pandemic has contributed to an increase in negative attitudes and pessimism in Spain, potentially shaping public views on emerging technologies like AI. Furthermore, the study stated that, misinformation, particularly related to scientific and technological matters, has fuelled heightened distrust and social anxiety among the Spaniards (Sánchez-Holgado et al., 2022).

The tangible nature of AI-associated risks, including data breaches, biased decision-making, and ethical dilemmas, makes these concerns more actionable for organisations (Rezaei et al., 2024; Wylde et al., 2023). In contrast, positive attitudes toward AI often remain abstract

and less immediate (Park & Woo, 2022; Schepman & Rodway, 2022). These findings suggest that policymakers and AI developers should prioritise addressing and mitigating perceived risks to promote the responsible adoption of AI technologies (Gupta et al., 2023).

5.2.2. Policy awareness: a multifaceted mediator

Policy awareness shows a significant relationship with public support for responsible AI. The study reveals that awareness enhances support across all regions—Australia ($\beta = 0.231$), the US ($\beta = 0.112$), and Spain ($\beta = 0.167$)—validating Hypothesis 5. This finding suggest that increased awareness of AI policies is related to greater support for responsible practices, similar to findings by Wang et al. (2018) regarding financial incentive policy awareness and support for electric vehicles.

The study also reveals interesting relationships between policy awareness and other factors (H6a – H6d). This highlights the critical importance of addressing widespread confusion surrounding AI technologies. Prior research (Miller, 2019; Zuiderwijk et al., 2021) emphasises that many individuals hold misconceptions about how AI operates. In our study, AI policy awareness was strongly associated with positive attitudes (H6a: $\beta = 0.019$), perceived behavioural control (H6c: $\beta = 0.008$), and perceived risk (H6d: $\beta = 0.043$). These associations suggest that increasing awareness of AI policies at the local government level could significantly enhance the public understanding of AI, fostering more informed perspectives.

These results are consistent with König and Wenzelburger's (2020) conceptual work, which argues that effective policy awareness can help mitigate the negative impacts of AI. Our findings provide empirical support for the role of AI policy awareness in shaping public attitudes, which is crucial for encouraging responsible AI adoption in local government.

At the country-specific level, the relationship of AI policy awareness exhibits notable variations across Australia, the USA, and Spain, reflecting each nation's unique approach to AI governance at local government. In the Australian context, policy awareness significantly association with both perceived risk (H6d: $\beta = 0.082$) and positive attitudes (H6a: $\beta = 0.037$). This dual impact suggests that Australians, when more informed about AI policies, tend to become more aware of potential risks while simultaneously developing more positive attitudes toward AI. This finding aligns with Australia's proactive approach to AI governance, as evidenced by initiatives such as the AI Action Plan released in June 2021 (Australian Government, 2021). The plan's focus on developing trusted, secure, and responsible AI likely contributes to this balanced public perception. Australia's commitment to ethical AI is reflected in the growing public perception that policy awareness not only mitigates risks but also fosters a supportive environment for responsible AI practices.

In contrast, the USA (H6d: $\beta = 0.034$) and Spain (H6d: $\beta = 0.041$) showed a different pattern, where policy awareness primarily associated with perceived risk without a significant relationship to other behavioural factors. Americans are generally more concerned about the risks associated with AI than adopting a positive outlook toward its potential benefits. This heightened concern stems from various factors, including widespread fears of job displacement and cybersecurity threats.

For instance, the Pew Research Centre surveys show, 76 % of Americans worry about driverless vehicles being hacked, and 83 % express concerns about automation leading to job losses in industries like ridesharing (Faverio & Tyson, 2023). Political and ideological influences also play a role, with conservative individuals exhibiting greater sensitivity to AI risks due to their predisposition toward caution in uncertain scenarios (Elsey & Moss, 2023).

Additionally, media coverage often amplifies fears by focusing on AI's potential misuse, such as its role in spreading misinformation during elections—with older adults particularly influenced by television news (Yan et al., 2025). Despite these apprehensions, Rethink Priorities survey identified that Americans do recognise the potential for AI to bring societal benefits, with 48 % expecting more good than harm overall (Elsey & Moss, 2023). However, the emphasis on regulation and oversight reflects a cautious approach, as 67 % believe the government might fail to adequately regulate AI technologies like chatbots and autonomous systems such as autonomous mobility (Faisal et al., 2021; Faverio & Tyson, 2023). This combination of perceived risks and regulatory demands explains why the U.S. public tends to prioritise concerns over risks rather than embracing overwhelmingly positive attitudes toward AI.

Spain's AI policy framework aligns with the EU's risk-based regulatory approach, which prioritises harm mitigation over fostering public enthusiasm for AI adoption. The EU AI Act's four-tiered risk framework—prohibiting unacceptable risks (e.g., social scoring, manipulative AI) and imposing strict obligations on high-risk systems (e.g., AI in education, employment, and critical infrastructure)—directly shapes Spain's national AI policies (European Parliament, 2025). As a result, public awareness in Spain is more centred on recognising AI-related risks rather than on cultivating positive attitudes toward AI adoption.

5.2.3. The paradox of policy expectation: the realism effect

The relationship between local government AI policy awareness and policy expectations reveals a surprising paradox. The analysis revealed a statistically significant relationship between AI policy awareness and AI policy expectations (H7: $\beta = -0.026$). However, contrary to Hypothesis H7, which predicted a positive relationship, the observed relationship was negative. This inverse correlation suggests that individuals becoming more aware of AI policies may develop a more realistic understanding of the complexities and limitations inherent in current governance frameworks (Dwivedi et al., 2021). Consequently, higher levels of AI policy awareness appear to temper expectations for comprehensive policies at the local level (Kerr et al., 2020).

In contrast, the study finds a strong positive association between the intention of supporting responsible AI practices and local government AI policy expectations ($\beta = 0.0762$). This finding highlights the critical influence of public intention in shaping policy expectations within local government settings. Essentially, when individuals express a clear intention to endorse responsible AI practices, it not only reflects their support for such initiatives but also exerts pressure on local governments to meet these expectations (Floridi et al., 2022; Jackson & Panteli, 2023).

Cognitive dissonance theory posits that individuals experience psychological dissonance when expected performance and actual performance differ from one another (Festinger, 1957). In the context of policy expectations, when individuals have high expectations for AI policies but encounter unfulfilled outcomes, they may experience cognitive dissonance. For example, if citizens expect comprehensive and effective AI policies but are not being implemented as promised, they face a conflict between their initial expectations and the reality of the situation (Kerr et al., 2020). This dissonance may result in: (a) increased disengagement, (b) frustration with the government (local) bodies, (c) potential loss of trust in AI technologies and their governance (Kerr et al., 2020; Marikyan et al., 2023).

As people learn more about AI policies, they adjust their expectations to reflect real-world limitations. (Murgia, 2025; Ndzendze & Marwala, 2023). From a policy perspective, this effect underscores the necessity to ground public expectations in the realities of AI governance. As citizens become more aware about the intricacies involved in AI policy, their expectations can align more closely with actual policy outcomes.

When examined at the country level, the results reveal a more nuanced picture regarding local government AI policy awareness and expectations, with no statistically significant relationships observed, as posited in Hypothesis 7. This lack of significant relationship was consistent across Australia, the USA, and Spain, indicating a potentially universal trend in local governance contexts rather than a country-specific phenomenon.

The absence of a significant relationship between local government AI policy awareness and policy expectation is intriguing and warrants

further investigation. It may indicate that the public's expectations of local AI policies are shaped by factors beyond mere awareness, such as personal experiences with AI technologies in municipal services, local media coverage of AI initiatives, or broader community attitudes towards technological governance at the city or town level.

5.3. Implication for practitioners and policymakers

5.3.1. Policy awareness campaigns

Local governments should focus on building comprehensive AI policy awareness among the public (Dwivedi et al., 2021). This involves educating citizens on AI governance's complexities, limitations, and realistic timelines (Valle-Cruz et al., 2019). By fostering a nuanced understanding of AI technologies and their societal implications, local governments can help align public expectations with achievable policy outcomes (Kerr et al., 2020; Meng & Wu, 2017). Additionally, Bastos et al. (2022) stated that local governments must establish mechanisms for continuous updates and information dissemination. Regular newsletters, dedicated websites, and community bulletins can inform the public about the latest AI advancements and policy changes (Valle-Cruz et al., 2019).

5.3.2. Tailored communication strategies

Researchers have highlighted that local governments should create tailored communication strategies considering community diversity to improve AI policy awareness (Vesnic-Alujevic et al., 2020; Zuiderwijk et al., 2021). The study of Androutsopoulou et al. (2019) highlights an increasing adoption of chatbots and conversational agents in government. These tools are primarily employed to facilitate policy-oriented discussions and enhance public awareness of government policies (Androutsopoulou et al., 2019).

This finding underscores the potential of AI technologies enhance communication between governments and citizens, especially in the context of policy dissemination and engagement. However, while these innovative approaches show promise, it is crucial to maintain a balanced approach (Ahmed et al., 2020; Androutsopoulou et al., 2019). To ensure broad reach and relevance across diverse demographic groups, traditional media channels should also be incorporated into the communication strategy (Kerr et al., 2020). This multi-channel approach can help local governments effectively disseminate AI policy information and engage citizens across various platforms, catering to different preferences and technological comfort levels within diverse communities.

These findings underscore the importance of tailoring AI policy communication strategies to align with each country's cultural and political context. For example, Australia provides a valuable model for fostering a balanced perception of AI risks and benefits. Recent initiatives, such as the introduction of the Voluntary AI Safety Standard in August 2024 and the proposed mandatory guardrails for high-risk AI settings in September 2024, reflect a comprehensive strategy that addresses both innovation and safety concerns. These efforts highlight the critical need for policymakers to design policy awareness campaigns that not only increase public understanding and risk perception but also foster positive attitudes towards responsible AI practices. A well-rounded communication approach can ensure that AI policies resonate with diverse public values, enabling more effective and responsible governance.

5.3.3. Two-way communication strategies

Our findings further underscore the importance of activating robust communication platforms, as they reveal that increased AI policy awareness within local governments significantly associated with individuals perceived behavioural control ($\beta = 0.008$). This association aligns with Hypothesis 6c and may indicate that increased policy awareness is related to greater confidence in citizens' ability to engage with and influence AI-related decisions (Khatibi et al., 2021). Thus, facilitating citizen engagement in mediated platforms may ultimately support more informed and proactive participation in responsible AI practices (Rakova et al., 2021).

In sum, our study reveals significant associations between behavioural attitudes, perceived risk, and policy awareness regarding support for responsible AI practices. Notably, perceived risk shows a stronger relationship with support compared to behavioural attitudes, suggesting that concerns about potential negative consequences of AI may be more closely linked to support than positive sentiments. The research also highlights the potential role of policy awareness in public understanding and attitudes towards AI. Interestingly, increased policy awareness is associated with more tempered expectations of AI governance, a pattern we term the "realism effect."

These findings suggest the potential importance of tailored communication strategies, two-way engagement channels, and continuous education in enhancing public understanding of AI policies. The study indicates that to promote support for responsible AI practices and build trust in AI technologies, local governments may need to address perceived risks, foster policy awareness, and help align public expectations with achievable outcomes.

6. Conclusion

This study used econometric modelling to explore individuals' behavioural intentions towards supporting responsible AI practices in the context of local governments. TPB provided a theoretical framework for analysis. Data gathered from 1220 respondents across Australia, the US, and Spain were analysed using SEM. The proposed methodology took advantage of a multi-factor survey to capture significant associations between the factors under investigation.

The findings suggest that increasing public awareness of AI policies is associated with fostering more favourable attitudes among individuals. A noteworthy aspect of our findings is the relationship between increased policy awareness and the moderation of public expectations. As individuals develop a more nuanced understanding of the capabilities and limitations of AI policies, they may form more realistic AI policy expectation (Kerr et al., 2020).

Additionally, perceived risk demonstrates a stronger association with support for responsible AI practices than behavioural attitudes, indicating that concerns about the potential negative consequences of AI technologies are more motivating than positive sentiments. Additionally, our research confirms that individuals who better understand of AI policies demonstrate increased confidence in their ability to engage with and influence AI-related decisions.

Meanwhile, this study makes significant contributions to both theoretical and practical applications in AI governance. From a theoretical perspective, this research extends existing frameworks of TPB, by incorporating the dimensions of perceived risk, local government AI policy awareness and expectations. This extension provides a more nuanced understanding of how policy awareness and expectation associated with individual attitudes and behavioural intentions in the context of emerging AI technologies. Moreover, the findings contribute to the growing field of literature on the public perception of AI technologies by revealing the complex interplay between policy awareness, expectations, and behavioural factors.

Practically, the insights from this study offer valuable guidance for local governments grappling with the challenges of adopting responsible AI practices. Local authorities can leverage these findings to design targeted awareness campaigns that not only inform citizens about AI policies but also foster a balanced perception of AI's risks and benefits. For instance, developing multi-channel communication strategies, such as using social media, community workshops, and traditional media outlets, can ensure inclusivity and reach diverse demographic groups. Additionally, governments can employ interactive tools, such as AI-powered chatbots or public consultations, to engage citizens and encourage active participation in policy discussions. By implementing these strategies, local governments can enhance public understanding,

build trust, and ensure alignment between AI governance frameworks and community expectations.

Beyond the three countries analysed in this study, these findings hold significant implications for the design of international policies in similar contexts. The emphasis on public awareness, balanced risk-benefit perceptions, and transparent communication can guide policymakers in diverse governance regimes to adopt responsible AI practices. The proposed framework can be adapted to regions with varying levels of digital literacy and socio-political structures, offering a versatile approach to AI governance. International collaborations, such as policy exchanges or joint AI governance initiatives, can further leverage these insights to create harmonised guidelines addressing global concerns while respecting local nuances. By bridging local and international perspectives, this study underscores the importance of fostering inclusive and adaptive policy frameworks for responsible AI adoption, ensuring relevance and effectiveness across diverse cultural and political contexts.

Although this research offers useful theoretical insights and practical contributions, it is important to acknowledge number of limitations. These constraints not only help contextualise the findings but also inform future research directions in this rapidly evolving field.

First, AI policy awareness, expectations, and behavioural attitudes may differ significantly across regions, cultures, and levels of digital literacy. As this study focuses on three countries, its findings may have limited generalisability. Future research should examine a broader set of countries with varied settlement patterns, cultural contexts, political systems, and socioeconomic conditions to better understand how these factors shape AI policy awareness and adoption across governance models.

Second, although the study found minimal variation across demographic groups, the complex nature of AI suggests these factors may still play a role. Future studies should ensure representation from diverse sociodemographic segments to more fully uncover these effects.

Third, while the study employs the TPB to explore the influence of policy awareness on behavioural intention, TPB may not fully capture the complexities involved in AI adoption, including emotional and ethical dimensions. Integrating alternative theoretical lenses—such as digital ethics, algorithmic accountability, or adaptive governance—could enrich future analyses, particularly in accounting for institutional capacity variations across contexts.

Fourth, survey items were adapted from existing TPB and AI literature to suit the context of local government AI policy. Although this improves contextual fit, it lacks validated instruments specific to this domain. Future research should aim to develop robust, validated measures for assessing local government AI policy awareness and expectations to enhance reliability.

Fifth, the oversampling of participants from Spain may bias the results, making them more reflective of the Spanish context and reducing the comparability across the three countries. Future research should ensure more proportional sampling to enable balanced, cross-national comparisons.

Sixth, while SEM was used to analyse variable relationships, we acknowledge the risk of Type I error and that SEM does not establish causality. Future research employing experimental or longitudinal designs would help validate these findings and better assess causal relationships (Bollen & Pearl, 2013).

Next, the survey targeted general citizens to capture public sentiment, aligning with the study's aims. Nevertheless, this excludes perspectives from policymakers, AI practitioners, and local government officials. Future studies should include these stakeholders to develop a more holistic understanding.

Also, reliance solely on quantitative survey data may obscure deeper insights into public attitudes. Future research should adopt mixed-methods approaches—such as interviews, focus groups, or case studies—to provide richer, more nuanced understandings.

Finally, the study captures public sentiment at a single time point, which may not reflect the dynamic evolution of AI policy awareness. Longitudinal studies could track how perceptions and behaviours shift as policies and public engagement strategies develop.

While acknowledging these limitations, this study provides a strong foundation for future inquiry. As AI continues to transform local governance, our findings contribute to both theory and practice, paving the way for more effective, ethical, and citizen-centred AI adoption in local government contexts.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Anne David: Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Tan Yigitcanlar:** Writing – review & editing, Supervision, Conceptualization. **Kevin Desouza:** Writing – review & editing. **Karen Mossberger:** Writing – review & editing. **Pauline Hope Cheong:** Writing – review & editing. **Juan Corchado:** Writing – review & editing. **Prithvi Bhat Beeramoole:** Writing – review & editing, Methodology. **Alexander Paz:** Writing – review & editing, Methodology.

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Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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Appendix A. Items used to measure the model

Variable	Item	
Positive Attitude	*In which area do you think AI benefits local government?*	(Kerr et al., 2020; Selwyn & Gallo Cordoba, 2022; Yigitcanlar, Li, et al., 2023)
PA1	Improving efficiency in administrative task	
PA2	Making public service delivery more efficient and accessible	
PA3	Enhancing citizen satisfaction and engagement	
PA4	Addressing complex urban challenges and sustainability issues	
PA5	Improving infrastructure maintenance	
PA6	Enhancing public safety and security	
Perceived Risk	*What do you consider the biggest risk of AI technology in local government?*	(Ghotbi & Ho, 2021; Kerr et al., 2020; Selwyn & Gallo Cordoba, 2022; Yigitcanlar, Li, et al., 2023)
NA1	Job displacement and unemployment	
NA2	Ethical concerns on AI decision-making	
NA3	Loss of human responsibility	
NA4	Data privacy violations	

(*continued on next page*)

(*continued*)

Variable	Item	
NA5	Potential for bias and discrimination in AI algorithms	
NA6	Lack of legal standards on AI adoptions	
Subjective Norms	*Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements.*	
SN1	People important to me discuss the benefits of local government AI application with me	(Venkatesh et al., 2003)
SN2	People important to me discuss the risk of local government AI application with me	
SN3	People important to me could influence me to use local government AI applications	
Behavioural Control	*Please indicate your level of understanding with the following statements.*	
BC1	I am confident that my voice and opinion will help to develop local government AI	(Venkatesh et al., 2003)
BC2	I am confident in my ability to understand local government AI	
Awareness of local government AI policy	*Please indicate your level of agreement with the following statements*	
AW1	I know that some local government have policies on AI	
AW2	I understand how local government AI policies benefits the community	
AW3	I regularly seek information or updates about local government AI policies on my own	(Bulgurcu et al., 2010)
AW4	I have participated in local government discussion, workshops, or forums related to AI policy development	
Expectation of local government AI policy	*How important are the following factors for the local government while developing AI policies*	
EX1	Collaborating with stakeholders to ensure communities' diverse perspectives are considered	
EX2	Managing technology, human, and finance for effective resource allocation	
EX3	Ensuring data governance to safeguard the community's privacy and security	(David et al., 2024)
EX4	Promoting regulation to ensure the safest practices in the community	
Adoption of responsible AI	*How important do you think the following aspects are for the responsible use of AI in local government? AI that…*	(Li et al., 2023; Selwyn & Gallo Cordoba, 2022)
RAI1	respect human dignity and privacy	
RAI2	are more fairly distributed to all	
RAI3	are more harmless to human and the environment	
RAI4	financially affordable to citizens	
RAI5	flexible and easier to use	
RAI6	culturally inclusive	
RAI7	are more understandable	
RAI8	assure its security	
RAI9	transparently discloses its process	
RAI10	are more carefully designed	
RAI11	are more aligned with citizen needs	
RAI12	are more sustainable	
RAI13	ensures accountability	
RAI14	are involving wide stakeholder groups	
RAI15	are more regulated	

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